

Graduation Outcomes and Equity Gaps in U.S. Higher Education

Summary

This analysis examines institutional graduation outcomes using IPEDS data, with a focus on differences between Pell and non-Pell students. While overall graduation rates vary widely across institutions, most exhibit small but consistent gaps favoring non-Pell students. However, a subset of institutions shows substantially larger disparities, indicating that aggregate performance can mask important differences in student outcomes.

Key Findings

- 1 Most institutions exhibit positive equity gaps, with non-Pell students graduating at higher rates than Pell students
- 2 The magnitude of these gaps varies widely, with some institutions showing substantially larger disparities
- 3 Institutions with higher Pell enrollment tend to have lower overall graduation rates
- 4 Completion rates increase significantly between 4 and 6 years, with smaller gains between 6 and 8 years

Implications

- 1 High overall graduation rates do not necessarily indicate equitable student outcomes
- 2 Institutions may benefit from targeted interventions aimed at supporting Pell-eligible students
- 3 Evaluating institutional performance should include both aggregate outcomes and subgroup disparities
- 4 Extending support beyond the 4-year mark may improve completion outcomes for students who require additional time

Data & Methods

This analysis uses publicly available data from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), including Graduation Rates, Outcome Measures, Financial Aid, and Institutional Characteristics datasets. Data were cleaned and joined using SQL, and key metrics such as graduation rates and equity gaps were calculated at the institutional level. Institutions were filtered to ensure meaningful comparisons by excluding small cohorts.